

Stormy swirls

Most tornadoes develop from thunderstorms. Warm, moist air rises from the ground and meets cool, dry air, which is spinning around inside stormy clouds. A swirling column of air starts to form and extends toward the ground.

Large storms commonly have two swirling masses of air inside them. One twists clockwise, and the other counterclockwise.

A tornado can be up to 1 mile (1.6 k) high.

Tornadoes can be funnel shapes or thin rope-like shapes.

See also

To find out more about the weather, see the water cycle (32–33).

Speeding up

As warm air rises, the pressure inside the thunderstorm drops, and the swirling air speeds up. Air in a tornado can blow faster than 164 ft (50 m) per second.

Debris is swept up and violently thrown back out. Houses and trees are ripped apart.

As soon as the vertical mass of air reaches the ground, it makes a thunderous, roaring sound.